



Horseshoe Falls, on the Canadian side of Niagara Falls, is about 2,600 ft (800 m) wide. Europeans first discovered this natural wonder in 1677.

IN FRANCE, LOUIS XIV'S principal architectural endeavors concentrated on his **immense palace at Versailles**, just outside Paris. Louis was also determined to continue the transformation of the French capital, begun by his grandfather Henry IV at the start of the 17th century. Henry's intent had been to lift the city from medieval slum to a **capital worthy of the first power of Europe**—a city to rival Rome for its imposing public buildings and commanding spaces. The Louvre Palace, predictably, was significantly enlarged and remodeled, notably the east wing, whose stately façade encapsulated the **French taste for Classicism** at its most austere and precise. But the building that most memorably reflects Louis's contribution to Paris is **Les Invalides**, or more properly *L'Hôtel National des Invalides*. Part hospital, part retirement home for French soldiers, it was completed in 1676. Designed by Libéral Bruant (1635–97), Les Invalides was conceived on an grand scale, with vast formal gardens

sweeping up to its immense façade and 15 courtyards clustered behind. Its most memorable feature, the **lavish royal chapel L'Église du Dôme**, was added slightly later. Placed at the southern end of the complex, it was designed with a vast dome and spire, with details picked out in gold.

Louis XIV's reign marked one of the most **fertile periods of French literature**. The year 1677 saw the first performance of *Phèdre*, the greatest tragedy of French dramatist **Jean Racine** (1639–99). Dramatists such as Racine, Pierre Corneille (1606–84), and **Molière** (1622–73) thrived under royal patronage, captivating court audiences in different ways. Corneille and Racine reflected courtly concerns through their use of formal verse, classical themes, and emphasis on honor, virtue, and renunciation, while Molière's racy dramas mocked the social pretensions of the bourgeoisie. As a result of this rich and growing theatrical tradition, the **Comédie-Française** was established in Paris under

royal patronage. This official state theater aimed to showcase the glories of the French stage and French culture as widely as possible.

European explorers began to realize the **immensity of North America** as the 17th century progressed. The extraordinary variety and natural beauty of its landscape also continued to amaze. The **discovery of Niagara Falls** in 1677, a waterfall hugely larger than any in Europe, with over 6,000,000 cu ft (170,000 cum) of water thundering over it every minute, provoked wonder in the Old World. There is doubt as to which European can claim to have seen the falls first. However, the French Franciscan missionary Louis Hennepin (1626–1701), exploring at the request of King Louis XIV, is generally credited with their discovery, in 1677.

engraving of author



Religious work

This is the frontispiece from the third edition of John Bunyan's *The Pilgrim's Progress*, a hugely influential work in the 17th century.

One of **literature's most significant religious works** was published in February 1678. *The Pilgrim's Progress* was written by English writer and Christian preacher **John Bunyan** (1628–88), who completed much of the work while imprisoned in Bedford Gaol (jail). It was published in two parts (the second part appeared in 1684) and is an **allegorical tale** of an everyman's journey from this world to heaven. *The Pilgrim's Progress* has become one of the most translated books in history.

Les Invalides, Paris

These sumptuous buildings now contain museums and monuments relating to France's military history, and a hospital for war veterans.



A 19th-century image of the Asante, who dominated West Africa from the 1680s.

IN 1679, THE ENGLISH PARLIAMENT passed the **Habeas Corpus Act**. Like Magna Carta (see 1215), it represented a cornerstone of English liberty. It is the legal assertion that **no one may be unlawfully detained**.

The law was passed for pragmatic reasons rather than as a liberal **principle of justice**. Its aim was to prevent James, Duke of York, the Catholic brother and heir of Charles II, from arresting his Protestant opponents without legal justification, as Charles's

“YOU MAY HOLD THE BODY, SUBJECT TO EXAMINATION.”

English writ of Habeas Corpus, 1679

chief minister, the Earl of Clarendon, had begun to do. The underlying principle of the Act, which is incorporated into the **American Constitution**, remains fundamental to most Anglo-Saxon legal systems as an **ultimate guarantee of individual liberty**. However, in reality the law is hardly ever invoked.

In August 1680, the **Pueblo people** of the colony of New Mexico **rose against the Spanish occupiers** and drove them from the area for 12 years. Spanish claims to New Mexico, though dating back to Francisco Coronado's expeditions of the

1676 Anti-Mughal
Afghans revolt

1676 Completion
of Les Invalides,
Paris

1676 Russo-Turkish War begins
(to 1681)

December 4, 1676
Swedish defeat Danes
in Battle of Lund

February 21, 1677 Dutch
philosopher Baruch
Spinoza dies (b. 1632)

February 8, 1677
French astronomer
Jacques Cassini born
(d. 1756)

1677 First production of *Phèdre*,
by Jean Racine, in Paris

July 14, 1677 Swedish
defeat Danes in Battle of
Landskrong

1677 The *Pilgrim's Progress*,
by John Bunyan, published

March 4, 1678 Italian composer
Antonio Vivaldi born (d. 1741)

August 10, 1678 First
Treaty of Nijmegen, ending
Franco-Dutch War

1679 Colony of New
Hampshire established

May 27, 1679 Habeas Corpus,
cornerstone of English liberty,
becomes law